

Clinical Opiate Withdrawal Scale (COWS)^[A]⁽¹⁾⁽²⁾⁽³⁾⁽⁴⁾

Assess and rate each of the 11 criteria of the COWS. Each criterion is rated on a scale from 0 (least severe) to 5 (most severe). Add up the scores for all 11 criteria. This is the total COWS score for the patient at that time.^[B]⁽²⁾

***Resting pulse rate** - measured in beats per minute after patient is sitting or lying for one minute

- ☐ Pulse rate 80 or below (+0)
- ☐ Pulse rate 81 to 100 (+1)
- ☐ Pulse rate 101 to 120 (+2)
- ☐ Pulse rate greater than 120 (+4)

***Sweating** - over past half hour not accounted for by room temperature or patient activity

- ☐ No report of chills or flushing (+0)
- ☐ Subjective report of chills or flushing (+1)
- ☐ Flushed or observable moistness on face (+2)
- ☐ Beads of sweat on brow or face (+3)
- ☐ Sweat streaming off face (+4)

***Restlessness** - observation during assessment

- ☐ Able to sit still (+0)
- ☐ Reports difficulty sitting still, but is able to do so (+1)
- ☐ Frequent shifting or extraneous movements of legs/arms (+3)
- ☐ Unable to sit still for more than a few seconds (+5)

***Pupil size**

- ☐ Pupils pinned or normal size for room light (+0)
- ☐ Pupils possibly larger than normal for room light (+1)
- ☐ Pupils moderately dilated (+2)
- ☐ Pupils so dilated that only the rim of the iris is visible (+5)

***Bone or joint aches** - if patient was having pain previously, only the additional component attributed to opiates withdrawal is scored

- ☐ Not present (+0)
- ☐ Mild diffuse discomfort (+1)
- ☐ Patient reports severe diffuse aching of joints/muscles (+2)
- ☐ Patient is rubbing joints or muscles and is unable to sit still because of discomfort (+4)

***Runny nose or tearing** - not accounted for by cold symptoms or allergies

- ☐ Not present (+0)
- ☐ Nasal stuffiness or unusually moist eyes (+1)
- ☐ Nose running or tearing (+2)
- ☐ Nose constantly running or tears streaming down cheeks (+4)

***GI upset** - over last half hour

- ☐ No GI symptoms (+0)
- ☐ Stomach cramps (+1)

- ☐ Nausea or loose stool (+2)
- ☐ Vomiting or diarrhea (+3)
- ☐ Multiple episodes of diarrhea or vomiting (+5)

***Tremor** - observation of outstretched hands

- ☐ No tremor (+0)
- ☐ Tremor can be felt, but not observed (+1)
- ☐ Slight tremor observable (+2)
- ☐ Gross tremor or muscle twitching (+4)

***Yawning**

- ☐ No yawning (+0)
- ☐ Yawning once or twice during assessment (+1)
- ☐ Yawning 3 or more times during assessment (+2)
- ☐ Yawning several times per minute (+4)

***Anxiety or irritability**

- ☐ None (+0)
- ☐ Patient reports increasing irritability or anxiousness (+1)
- ☐ Patient obviously irritable or anxious (+2)
- ☐ Patient so irritable or anxious that participation in the assessment is difficult (+4)

***Gooseflesh skin**

- ☐ Skin is smooth (+0)
- ☐ Piloerection of skin can be felt or hairs standing up on arms (+3)
- ☐ Prominent piloerection (+5)

Calculate

Reset

Score: 48

Scale for scoring

Score of 0 to 4: Absent or minimal withdrawal

Score of 5 to 12: Mild withdrawal

Score of 13 to 24: Moderate withdrawal

Score of 25 to 36: Moderately severe withdrawal

Score of more than 36: Severe withdrawal